

Dutch Golden Age

After its independence in 1648, the Dutch Republic became one of the wealthiest and most powerful countries in the world, dominating international trade and creating a vast colonial empire. Merchants became wealthier, creating the first bourgeois society, and also the most religiously tolerant country in Europe. In such circumstances, great advancements were made in the arts and sciences. Many renowned painters, including Rembrandt and Vermeer, came to prominence.

With no church patronage, relatively few biblical paintings were produced. Instead, popular genres included scenes of peasant life, landscapes, townscapes, seascapes, flower paintings and still lifes. The idealization and splendour of Baroque art was absent. Most paintings were relatively small, with group portraits being an exception. Best known for these and his single portraits of the wealthy, Frans Hals (c.1582–1666) also painted scenes of daily life with wit and loose painterly brushwork. Gerrit Dou (1613–75) and Jan Steen (1626–79) specialized in dramatically lit genre scenes.



Rembrandt, *The Night Watch*, 1642